

Handling Difficult People

Elective Skills Training — Counts Toward 32-Hour Requirement

Duration: 4 Hours

Authority: BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b)



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MODULE 1

Communication Strategies with Difficult Individuals

BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b)

Communication Principles

Separate the person from the problem — address behavior, not character

Lead with empathy: 'I understand this is frustrating' — disarms defensiveness

Use 'I' statements: 'I need you to lower your voice' vs. 'You are being disruptive'

Avoid 'You always' or 'You never' — generalizations escalate conflict

Silence is a tool: pause after speaking — do not fill every gap

Speak to the adult: treat everyone as capable of making a better choice

Listening Under Pressure

Let difficult people vent briefly — interrupting increases hostility

Acknowledge what was said before responding: 'I hear you. Here is what I can do...'

Avoid interrupting — even when you disagree

Watch for underlying needs: anger often masks fear, humiliation, or helplessness

Paraphrase what you heard to show understanding and reduce misunderstanding

Take notes — visible note-taking signals that you are taking the person seriously



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MODULE 2

Conflict Management & Speaking Constructively

BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b)

Stages of Conflict Escalation

POTENTIAL: tension exists but conflict has not erupted — intervene here

PERCEIVED: parties believe conflict exists — clarify before it escalates

FELT: emotional — hostility rising — active listening and empathy needed

MANIFEST: open conflict — requires structured de-escalation

AFTERMATH: conflict subsided — document, follow up, and debrief

Best outcomes: intervene at Potential or Perceived stage

Speaking Constructively

Focus on behavior, not identity: 'That action is a problem' vs. 'You are a problem'

State expectations clearly: 'I need you to step back to this line'

Give a reason: 'For everyone's safety, I need you to wait here'

Offer a realistic choice: 'You can wait calmly, or I will need to ask you to leave'

Follow through: empty threats destroy credibility and escalate next encounter

Debrief after difficult interactions — identify what worked and what to improve



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MODULE 3

Valuing Diversity & Negotiating Peaceful Outcomes

BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b)

Valuing Diversity in Conflict

Cultural norms: some cultures express disagreement loudly — not necessarily threatening

Language barriers in conflict: slow down, simplify, do not raise your voice

Age: older persons may respond differently to authority — adjust tone accordingly

Gender dynamics: be aware of perception in same-gender vs. cross-gender conflicts

Disability: behavioral differences may not indicate hostility — assess context

Neutral, consistent enforcement: apply the same standards to everyone

Basic Negotiation for Security Guards

Interests vs. positions: understand what the person actually needs, not just what they are demanding

Find common ground: 'We both want to resolve this calmly'

Offer options: giving choices reduces resistance and increases compliance

Avoid win/lose framing: outcomes where both parties feel heard are more durable

Know your limits: you cannot negotiate away the law or post orders

When negotiation fails: escalate to supervisor — do not make unauthorized concessions



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MODULE 4

Verbal Diffusion — Defusing Hostile & Aggressive Behavior

BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b)

Verbal Diffusion Techniques

Lower your own voice when the other person raises theirs — modeling calm

Name the emotion: 'It sounds like you are really frustrated right now'

Validate without agreeing: 'I understand why you would feel that way'

Redirect: 'Let's focus on how we can fix this' — moves from past to future

Strategic agreement: agree on minor points to reduce overall tension

Humor (carefully): light humor from a calm guard can break tension — never sarcasm

When Verbal Diffusion Is Not Working

Recognize the point of no return: continued verbal engagement may escalate

Create distance: step back, change location, reduce stimuli

Disengage without capitulating: 'I am going to give you a moment to think about this'

Request backup: do not handle escalating situations alone

Establish a perimeter: keep bystanders away from the conflict zone

Document: record all verbal attempts to diffuse in your incident report



Course Complete

Handling Difficult People

Proceed to the online assessment. A score of 100% is required to receive your BSIS Certificate of Completion per BPC §7583.6(b) | Title 16 CCR §643(b).